Paradigm Justification Statement

Deisy Lizbeth Acosta Ticse

1. Research topic and context

Generative AI has entered Peruvian undergraduate coursework while local evidence is still emerging: a survey across four Peruvian universities associated ChatGPT use with students' ethical concerns and called for responsible-use programs (Acosta-Enriquez et al., 2024). In my courses I observe a recurring pattern of full delegation: students paste the assignment into a chatbot and submit the output without mediating it through their own judgment. Detectors and sanctions may curb this behavior, but they do not form the capacity to deliberate.

2. Preliminary research question

RQ1 (design): How can a conversational agent grounded in virtue ethics scaffold ethical deliberation when undergraduates at a Peruvian university delegate work to generative AI?
RQ2 (evaluation): Does forming autonomous judgment through this agent outperform restricting behavior, increasing metacognitive reflection and product integrity and reducing AI dependence relative to unrestricted and restrictive-normative conditions?

3. Chosen paradigm and justification

I adopt Design Science Research (DSR), a paradigm in which knowledge of a problem and its solution is produced by building and evaluating an artifact, and claims are judged by the artifact's utility in context (Hevner et al., 2004). Because my question is prescriptive, my intended contribution is a nascent design theory: virtue-based design principles, instantiated in an agent and an annotated dataset, then empirically evaluated (Gregor & Hevner, 2013). Positivism cannot govern this study because it explains and predicts what already exists, whereas my object must first be designed; measuring without building would quantify the problem, not address it, and its hypothetico-deductive logic survives only within DSR's evaluation (Venable et al., 2016). Interpretivism would clarify how students experience delegation, useful design input, but it produces neither the artifact nor the comparative evidence an institution needs before adoption. Mixed methods, even in intervention designs (Fetters et al., 2013), integrate data to describe and explain rather than to produce design principles, so they serve as DSR's evaluation repertoire, not as my paradigm. DSR thus yields the contribution; a three-condition quasi-experiment supplies the evidence.

4. Implications

My data are a Spanish-language corpus of academic-integrity scenarios annotated for the four cardinal virtues plus honesty, with inter-annotator agreement (kappa), and outcome measures of reflection, dependence and integrity. My methods follow the DSR build–evaluate cycle, ending in a quasi-experiment across my own course sections. My contribution is a set of evaluated design principles and a Spanish-language resource for Latin America. Coherent venues are Computers & Education, DESRIST and IEEE-RITA, which respectively value learning-technology impact, design-theory contributions and Ibero-American reach.

5. One doubt or tension

My main doubt is a reliability–validity trade-off: the more operational my definition of prudence, the higher inter-annotator agreement is likely to be, but the closer the construct drifts toward a rulebook, the very restrictive-normative logic I question. I will mitigate this through expert-validated definitions and piloting, reporting disagreement rather than simplifying the construct.

References

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